



Disparities in cervical cancer prevention and early detection among immigrants in Italy: The DCIMIT study protocol

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Background

- Immigrant women in Italy have a higher risk of cervical cancer (OR=3.54), are diagnosed at younger ages and at more advanced stages compared to Italian women.
- Despite free access to organized screening programs, they show lower participation rates¹ (Figure 1) and worse outcomes for cervical cancer.²
- The DCIMIT study aims to address disparities in cervical cancer prevention and early detection among immigrant women in Italy.

DCIMIT

Disparities in Cervical cancer among IMmigrants in ITaly

Methods

- This is a national project supported by the AIRC Foundation for Cancer Research in Italy and coordinated by the University of Bologna (IT).
- Three studies are planned:
 1. A mixed-methods multicenter study to identify determinants influencing early detection and access to care among immigrant women in Italy diagnosed with HSIL or cervical cancer (n=300);
 2. A register-based analysis to compare incidence and mortality of cervical cancer between immigrants and non-immigrants;
 3. A community-based intervention study to evaluate the impact of a culturally tailored educational intervention on the screening participation of healthy immigrant women in Rome (n=205) compared to a control group (Figure 2).
- The project started in 2025 and will last for 5 years.

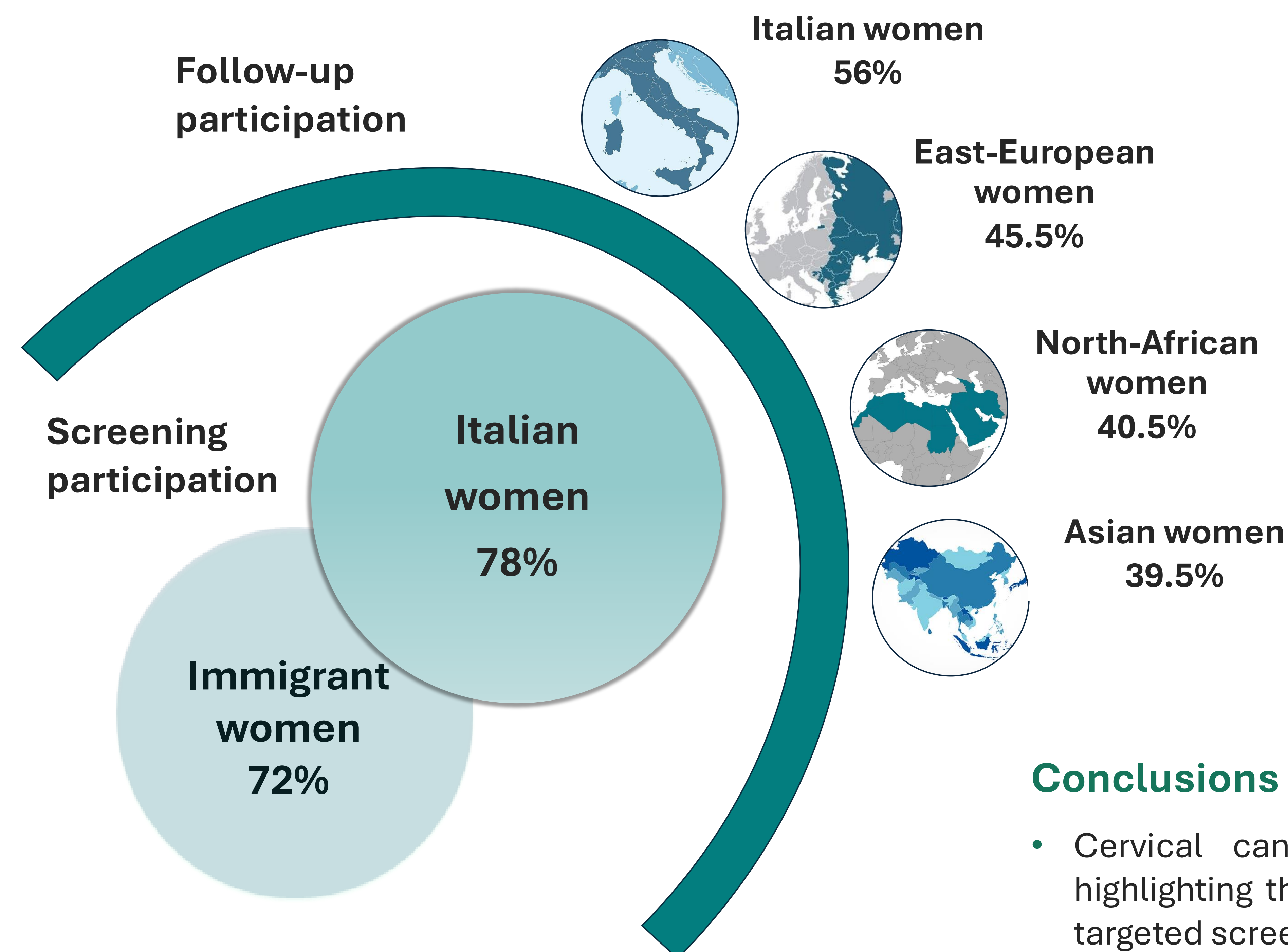


Figure 1. Participation rates

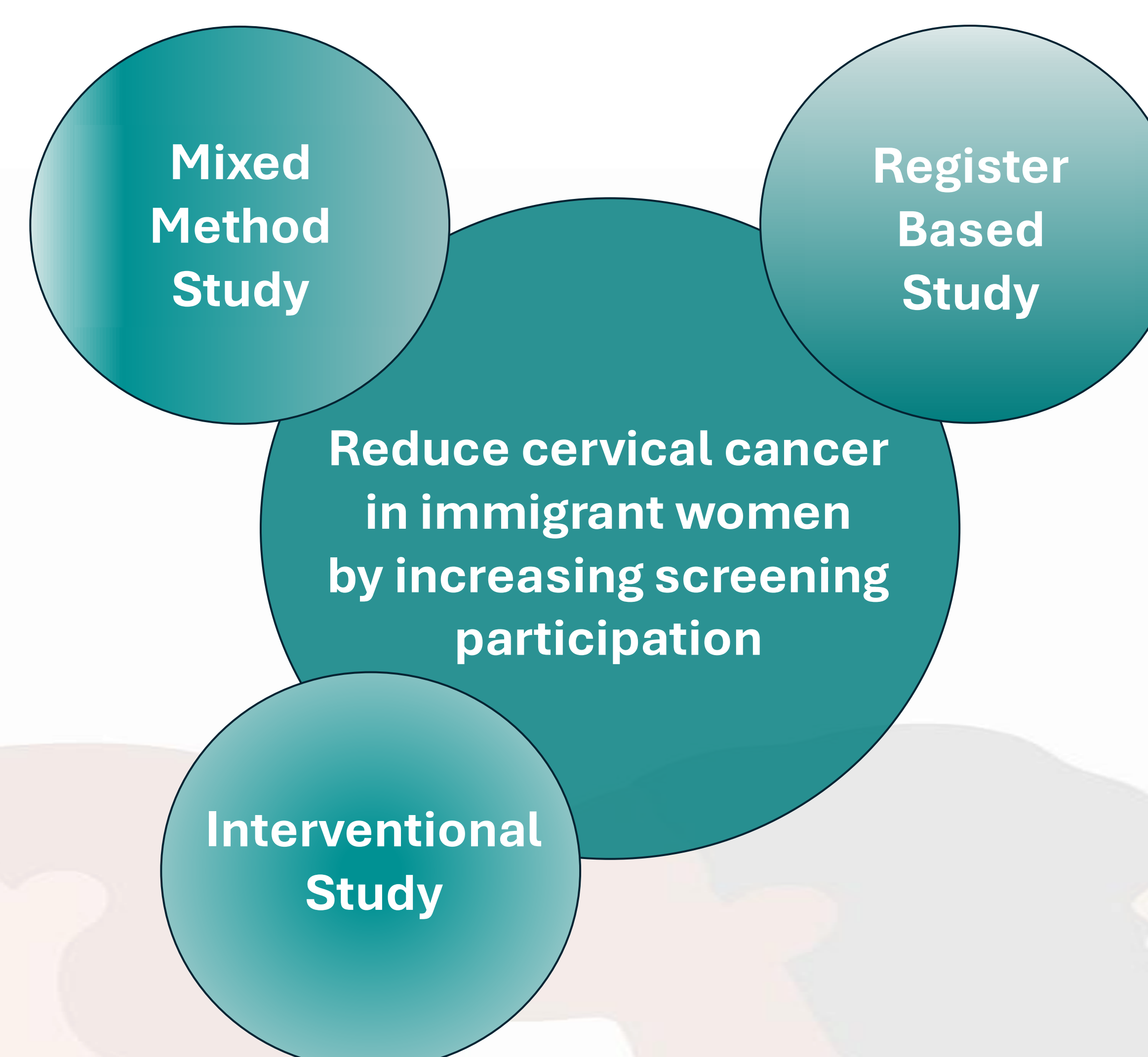


Figure 2. Project Structure

Results

- Expected results from the mixed-methods study include identifying the prevalence and relevance of self-reported barriers and facilitators to the early detection of cervical cancer and access to care.³
- In the registry-based study, we expect to find a higher incidence of cervical cancer among immigrants and lower survival rates compared to Italian-born patients across Italy.²
- In the intervention study, we expect that a culturally sensitive educational program could lead to an increase in screening uptake among healthy immigrants.^{4,5}

Conclusions

- Cervical cancer disproportionately impacts immigrants, highlighting the urgent need for inclusive health monitoring, targeted screening, and equity-focused prevention policies.
- DCIMIT represents the first comprehensive research project in Italy addressing disparities in cervical cancer prevention and early detection among immigrant women.
- This project is expected to generate new evidence to support policy changes, develop culturally appropriate health education strategies, and inform future efforts aimed at reducing cancer-related inequities.

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The authors declare no conflict of interest

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